I relay this in order to point out that Iran's decision to develop nonconventional strategic capabilities was made in the early 1990s, almost twenty years ago (at the time of writing) and more than twenty-five years before this book was published. Today, no serious person carries any doubt about Iran's intentions to develop military nuclear capability. It is also now impossible to deny that for twenty years the Iranians managed to deceive the world and sell it the story (which was convenient for the world to buy) that their nuclear program was solely for peaceful purposes. Today, with the Iranians already having obtained long-range (3,500 km) missile capability and chemical and biological capabilities, and with nuclear military capability just around the corner, they have already begun to realize their goal of strategic hegemony in the Middle East. The first Gulf state to announce its recognition of this development was Qatar, which had already concluded several years earlier that the United States could not be relied upon and had aligned itself with Iran. Moreover, Iran now has a heavy military presence on the ground in Iraq, and the two countries can be defined as "sister states," with their common denominator being Shiite Islam. Iran has a massive presence, both directly and through groups of foreign fighters (Chechens, Turkmen, and others) in Syria and Lebanon, and Iran has also been taking an active part in the civil war in Yemen.

The Iranian move in Lebanon was astute, and today Hezbollah, with its high-trajectory strategic capabilities, is a first-rate threat that Israeli policy planners cannot ignore. The military experience that Hezbollah acquired in the war against ISIS in Syria should not be underestimated; today it should be treated as a regular army and not as a terrorist organization.

The evacuation of US military forces from Iraq will turn it into a vacuum to be occupied by Iranian strategic influence. The Iranians have been operating inside Iraq for years, expanding their base of influence, with their natural allies being the Shiites, who constitute a clear majority of Iraq's population. As of 2017, Iranian military forces and security advisers belonging to the IRGC are fighting side by side with the Iraqi Shiite army against ISIS in order to try to drive it out of Iraq. Following the departure of the American forces, the next aim of the Iranians and their Shiite allies will be to strike and terrorize the American civilian organizations that are likely to replace the US Army. Washington will not go to war again to protect these American citizens. They will leave Iraq, the issue will disappear from the media's agenda, and Iraq will become a de facto protectee of Iran. It